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DELHI | It's War on Maoists

The Home Ministry, it seems, has finally woken up to the Naxal threat and is preparing for an all-out war against the Maoists. Home Minister P. Chidambaram is giving final touches to the blueprint of the biggest-ever operation with the option of using attack helicopters. Over 20,000 personnel from the Border Security Force (BSF) and Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) are now undergoing specialised training, with a select team being sent to the army's Counter Insurgency and Jungle Warfare School at Vairengte, Mizoram. The school will train personnel to lead operations in Maoist hotbeds such as the Orissa-Andhra Pradesh border. A Special Tactics Wing has also been established at the National Police Academy, Hyderabad, to provide leadership training. Expecting the operation to last a few years, the Home Ministry is in regular consultation with paramilitary, army and air force officers for inputs. Though the option of using airborne gunships is being seen as the "last resort", air force copters will be used to provide logistical support to transfer personnel and material in Naxal country. The heavily-armed Maoists are present in almost 200 districts in the country and control sizeable chunks in Orissa, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Bihar and West Bengal. It looks as if the Home Ministry has taken a cue from the recent Sri Lankan offensive against the LTTE. *by Bhavna Vij-Aurora*

**ANTI-NAXAL
OPERATIONS IN
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